On the stage is a huge bell, decorated with orchids and marigolds. Seated next to it are men in sharp suits, delivering equally sharp speeches. As soon as the clock strikes 15:40, they all rise and ring the ceremonial bell, closing the first session of the SGX-Nifty, now rechristened GIFT Nifty. Based on the National Stock Exchange (NSE)'s Nifty index, it is a cross-border initiative connecting the capital markets of India and Singapore. In the packed banquet hall of the GIFT City Club, financial experts, consultants and traders, most of whom have flown in from Mumbai and Singapore, listen to speeches and presentations that elaborate how the Gujarat International Finance Tec (GIFT) City—located in the state's Gandhinagar district—is bringing home opportunities for India as an offshore financial centre (OFC).

Step outside the swanky club, and you find yourself staring at the future. Shiny, tarred roads are lined with towering buildings, and equally tall construction cranes on projects that are work-in-progress. Approaching the venue from the airport, one passes several under-construction flyovers and elevated metro rails, until the cluster of 14 modish buildings emerges as an oasis in the middle of a deserted landscape. KPMG, one of the 'Big Four' consulting firms that 30-something Deven Jain (*name changed*) works with, has leased an office in one of these buildings.

That afternoon on July 3, sitting in a corner of the hall, the

IN NUMBERS

TOTAL AREA 886 ACRES

261 ACRES IFSC & SEZ*

625 ACRES Domestic Tariff Area

TOTAL ENTITIES IN IFSC & SEZ: 400

- **35** Fintech firms
- **64** Ancillary firms
- **2** International stock exchanges — ***$30.6 bn:*** *Average daily trading volume*
- **23** Insurance firms/ intermediaries — ***$30 bn:*** *Sum assured*
- **1** Bullion exchange — ***75:*** *Qualified jewellers onboarded*
- **63** Fund management companies — ***$14.6 bn:*** *Capital committed*
- **23** International banking units — ***$36.5 bn:*** *Cumulative asset size*
- **24** Aircraft leasing and financing entities — ***15:*** *Aircraft leased*

**International Financial Services Centre & Special Economic Zone*



Photographs by **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR**